



Captain Courageous

DELHI As the most famous face in Indian football, skipper of the national team and one who stood by his players, Baichung Bhutia has been known in soccer circles as "Captain Courageous".

Last week, there was more proof that the sobriquet sat comfortably on the Padmashree winner, the only Indian to have played first division football in England. Selected

by the Indian Olympic Association to carry the Beijing Olympic torch on its Indian leg when it reaches Delhi on April 17, Bhutia, a Buddhist, refused the offer saying he "sympathised with the Tibetan cause. I abhor violence in any form. This is my way of standing by the people of Tibet and their struggle".

He said he was not pressured by Tibetan

STANDING BY A CAUSE: Bhutia won't bear the torch

groups and insisted it was "a personal decision. I feel what is happening is not right and I should show my solidarity in my small way". Though Bhutia rejected the offer to carry the torch in a fax message to Suresh Kalmadi, the IOA president denied having received it.

Bhutia's principled stand on the issue is in stark contrast with some of the other sportspersons who have been similarly invited to take part in the torch relay ceremony. A top golfer said he too had been invited for the function and confirmed that he would indeed be carrying the torch. While admitting that he was aware of the goings on in Tibet, he justified his decision to go ahead with the marathon relay with the amazing explanation that "the Indian government is not protesting, so why should I?" This left many wondering if he was a Politburo member in the garb of a golfer.

by Rahul Tewari

Winner Takes It All

DELHI Hindi television news channel Aaj Tak added another feather to its cap when it won the Best News Channel Award for 2007 at the Sansui Television Awards on March 29. This is the second consecutive year when Aaj Tak has bagged the award, consolidating its place as the best news channel in the country.

Along with that, the Best TV Anchor Award was won by INDIA TODAY Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for the



THE BEST: Aaj Tak

celebrity interview show, *Seedhi Baat* on Aaj Tak. Prior to this, Chawla has also won the Indian Television Academy Award for the Best Talk Show Host, while *Seedhi Baat* has won the Radio and Television Advertising Practitioners' Association of India award for the Best Talk Show. Aaj Tak has also won the Television Academy's Best News Channel of the Year award for six consecutive years.

Aroon Purie, chairman and managing director of TV Today, said, "Winning all three best news channel awards clearly demonstrates Aaj Tak's complete dominance in the news space. I am really happy that Aaj Tak has evolved into a power brand and is synonymous with television news in India."

OBJECT OF DESIRE

Thin as Air

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